Client Context Initial Analysis

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Client: Dietrich College Dean's Office of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion
Client Contact: Ayana Ledford (Associate Dean for DEI)

Community Partner Background

About the Organization

The mission of the Dietrich College Dean's Office of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) is to "*provide oversight on diversity, equity and inclusion issues and facilitates communication and accountability*" [1]. The office is organized into an advisory committee and an implementation committee [2], with both parties working together to bring inclusion to programs, events, and resources in the community. They monitor DEI initiatives within the larger Dietrich ecosystem, the second-largest academic unit at CMU. Thus, they reach large audiences that span across all undergraduate students, graduate students, faculty, and staff [3]. With many goals and tasks, the DEI system appears to be decentralized and dynamic. They communicate through part-time volunteers to collect data on initiatives coordinated with different faculties, programs, and student organizations. As an example, they collect metrics on the demographics of event participants.

Programs

To support the mission of diversity, equity, and inclusion, the office leads many initiatives. In fact, they have previously released a strategic plan in fall 2020 [4] that introduced several new programs and goals. Some of these new works include improving scholar and research opportunities, establishing DEI awards, and creating exciting courses on topics like bias, discrimination, anti-racism, and anti-sexism. Some of the interesting and popular undergraduate courses include 85350 Psychology of Prejudice, 82-283 Language Diversity & Cultural Identity, 85-357 Navigating Race and Identity in America: The Role of Psychology in Racial Interactions, and 79-226 African History: Earliest Times to 1780 [1]. These course offerings not only reflect the office's dedication and commitment to DEI but also engage undergraduate students in new and fun ways.

The office has also made notable accomplishments such as expanding the amount of admissions counselors to prioritize diversity, joining organizations like Vibrant Pittsburgh and the LEAP program, and expanding professional development opportunities. Lastly, the Dietrich College Dean's Office of DEI is responsible for collecting data on all of the DEI events, programs, workshops, and more. Statistics help determine the level of outreach and success of the initiative.

Staff

Associate Dean Ayana Ledford is the point of contact for the Dietrich College Dean's Office of DEI. As the strongest advocate for our project, she is likely a good person to entrust with the project's long-term health. A problem that she faces is that her current system of communicating with her network of volunteer collaborators is too inefficient.

She is often chasing old emails to follow-up with volunteers—and they enforce no standard for recording data. Periodically, she must request demographic information from the undergraduate admissions office which takes up to a month to compile a report.

Organization members volunteer to collect data for DEI and send it by email to Ayana. These volunteers are part-time, and no formal system exists to teach or enforce a uniform set of standards. When considering the volunteer's key role in data collection, we should build systems that allow them to deliver reports quickly, easily, and perhaps with a reminder system. We don't precisely know how many they work with. In passing, we heard that Vince and Nicole are more familiar with technical details and could help us understand the CMU website's Content Management System (CMS)z.

Information Management

As the Dietrich College Dean's Office of DEI implements strategies and manages initiatives, they work with large amounts of data. For instance, DEI events produce data such as the number of attendees, demographics of attendees, the number of hosts, and more. This information is critical for understanding the outreach levels and assessing the impact of their initiatives. Currently, there is no information management system to house all this critical data. Instead, the associate dean for DEI manages emails and excel spreadsheets from multiple faculty, staff, and volunteers. Thus, there is a lot of additional effort required to gather the information and the overall process is inefficient and time-consuming for all parties involved.

Community Partner Project Opportunity

Project Opportunity

The biggest challenge the Dietrich DEI committee faces is collecting, storing, and accessing committee data in a centralized format. Currently, when events and initiatives are led by committees, there is no defined way for them to forward attendance and participation to Ayana's office. Ayana often reaches out to the different departments in Dietrich herself to gather the data, which has proven to be extremely inefficient and time-consuming. She also reaches out to the master's admissions office, as demographic data about their admission is much harder to obtain than the undergraduate admissions data. Their primary system consists of Excel spreadsheets sent via email, which can easily get lost and difficult to synthesize with other committees.

Establishing a more efficient and organized system for collecting data on DEI initiatives is important because currently, the Dietrich College Dean's Office of DEI cannot accurately assess impact. They cannot determine how well the programs are going nor

what programs are happening within separate departments. They are missing the opportunity to collect crucial data and to measure the success of all their hard work.

A technology solution that allows committees to easily store data, describe their events, and allows Ayana's team to instantly view and organize it would greatly benefit the organization. Additionally, by having a single source for DEI data, tools like Tableau could be utilized to seamlessly create graphics to post to the public. By monitoring trends in the data library, Ayana and the Deitrich College dean would know what works best for implementing DEI efforts in Dietrich College.

Proposed Project Vision

Given the current problems Ayana's office faces, our team's priority is to develop a system that improves the speed of collecting data and storing it long-term. Our idea is to use a standardized Google Form template for committee members to fill out with admission statistics, event participation demographics, and other initiatives. This would provide a user-friendly solution that the less tech-savvy members could still understand and properly use. If we create a pipeline to transfer and aggregate the Google form data to an Excel spreadsheet, Ayana's team would have real-time access to committees' work. Additionally, we are considering developing a backend website for committees to visit every time they want to input information and avoid large email chains. Lastly, since Ayana mentioned other Dietrich offices use Tableau for data visualization, we can develop preliminary graphics with Ayana to possibly publish on the Deitrich website. This would allow the committee to easily digest the information with visuals that would display all the DEI achievements and may reach even larger audiences such as the public.

User Stories

1. As an Associate Dean for DEI, I want to know how many people attended an event so that I can gauge interest and outreach success.
2. As an Associate Dean for DEI, I want to know the demographics of the people who attended so that I can measure the impact of our initiatives.
3. As an Associate Dean for DEI, I want a standardized way of data collection across departments so that I can save time retrieving data.
4. As a Department Head, I want to know the biggest event from another department so that I can implement similar initiatives in my department.
5. As a DEI Volunteer, I want to fill out a form so that I can easily contribute data to DEI.

Resources

1. https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/index.html
2. https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/committees.html

3. https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/strategic-plan.html
4. https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/docs/diversity-equity-inclusion-strategic-plan.pdf